

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Malachi 1:1

This is the message (literally *An Oracle: The message*) that the Lord gave to Israel: This superscription classifies the book of Malachi as an authoritative message from God and identifies the author and audience, though not the date or occasion. The word *oracle* imbues Malachi's message with authority and urgency. His audience was expected to pay attention and respond.

Malachi 1:2

loved: In portraying a relationship between the Lord and Israel, love has covenant implications. The term may be equated with God's choice, or *election*, of Israel as his people. Malachi's message indicates that the other dimensions of God's unconditional covenant love for Israel (such as his patient mercy; see [3:6](#), [17](#)) are also still operative. See also [Rom 9:13](#).

Malachi 1:2–5

Malachi's sermons are literary *disputations*—a format that calls to mind the setting of a courtroom and establishes the tone of a trial for the prophet's message. This first disputation presents the truth that God loves Israel ([1:2](#)). The prophet then debates this thesis with his audience in the five messages that follow.

Malachi 1:3

rejected (literally *hated*, the antonym of *loved* in [1:2](#)): Love and hate form a polar word pair in Old Testament legal and prophetic texts (see [Deut 7:9–10](#); [Amos 5:15](#)), often used to describe the alienation of a broken covenant relationship. Here, God says that he rejected Esau (and his descendants, the Edomites). Esau had despised and rejected covenant relationship with the Lord (see [Gen 25:34](#); [26:34–35](#)). • Esau was the ancestor of the Edomite nation, and his inheritance, the territory of Edom, was located on the southeastern rim of the Dead Sea. The mention of Jacob and Esau

calls to mind the twin brothers' rivalry ([Gen 25:23–26](#)).

Malachi 1:4

the Lord of Heaven's Armies (Hebrew *Yahweh tseba'oth*): This name for God is prominent in Old Testament prophetic literature. *Heaven's Armies* are the angelic armies at God's command; the phrase emphasizes the invincible power of God. • The Land of Wickedness: Esau was selfish and contemptuous of the tokens of the Lord's covenant (see [Gen 25:34](#)). The nation of Edom came to personify the pride of self-centered existence (see [Jer 49:16](#)). The Edomites were also allies of Babylon in the destruction of Jerusalem (see [Ps 137:7–9](#); [Obad 1:10, 12](#)).

Malachi 1:6

shown contempt for my name: God's name is his reputation or character (cp. [Ezek 36:19–24](#)). The Judeans were showing how little they thought of God by giving him worthless offerings.

Malachi 1:6–2:9

Malachi's second message affirms the Lord's role as God and Father of Israel; he alone deserves true worship. The first part ([1:6–14](#)) shows how the Israelites had dishonored God in spite of his fatherly care and masterly power. The second part ([2:1–9](#)) warns the priests of Judah against sacrificing sick and defective animals and faults them for not teaching God's instructions ([2:6–8](#)).

Malachi 1:7

defiled the sacrifices?: Ritual uncleanness or contamination disqualified an object or person from being in the ceremonies of worship to the Lord. The defilement in this case resulted from ignoring the laws concerning acceptable animal sacrifices ([Lev 22:17–25](#); [Deut 15:21](#)).

Malachi 1:8

The governor was Persia's appointed overseer of the province of Judah. The juxtaposition of *my altar* ([1:7](#)) and *your governor* ([1:8](#)) reveals a confusion of loyalties among the Levitical priests. • says the Lord of Heaven's Armies: This phrase is known as the messenger formula in prophetic speech and signifies that God's authority stands behind the prophet's message.

Malachi 1:12

Dishonor was an ongoing state of affairs. Ironically, the guardians of Israel's covenant relationship with the Lord were habitually profaning his Temple with impure sacrifices.

Malachi 1:14

Cursed: To "bind with a curse" was to deliver an individual over to misfortune as punishment for a serious crime against the community (see [Deut 27:15-26](#); [Jer 48:10](#)). Malachi spoke for the Lord, so the curse was a pronouncement of doom.

Malachi 2:2

make up your minds: This was an issue of the will, not the emotions. • terrible curse: Malachi had in mind the utter destruction of those who violated God's covenant (see [Deut 28:20](#)).

Malachi 2:4

my covenant with the Levites: If the Levites would give themselves to serving God and forsake their own glory, God would give them life and peace ([2:5](#); cp. [Num 8:5-26](#); [25:12-13](#)). Their special responsibility was to teach God's instructions ([Mal 2:7](#)).

Malachi 2:7

The priests had been entrusted with the sacred knowledge of God as revealed in the law of Moses. Through their role as teachers, they were guardians of God's covenant with Israel ([Deut 33:9-10](#)). • messenger (Hebrew *mal'ak*): This may

be a wordplay on the name *Malachi* (*mal'aki*). Usually this title was reserved for Hebrew prophets in the Old Testament, but Malachi ascribes prophetic duties to the priest, since the priests were to interpret God's word.

Malachi 2:9

shown favoritism (literally *lifted up the face*): The expression is also found in [1:8](#) ("see how pleased he is"). The priests should have administered the law with kindness and fairness, but they had not done so. It was ridiculous for the priests to suppose that God would show them favor when they had shown partiality in discharging the prescribed duties of their office.

Malachi 2:10

children of the same Father . . . created by the same God (or *by one God*): These divine titles underscore the Lord's uniqueness as Creator and his exclusive role as Israel's Father. *One God* echoes the *Shema*, Israel's creed of monotheism ([Deut 6:4-5](#)). • betray: The central thesis of this third message is that divorce is a betrayal. • covenant of our ancestors: The prophet alludes to the covenant formed at Mount Sinai, reminding the people that the law of Moses stipulated responsibility both to God and to one another.

Malachi 2:10-16

Malachi's third message shows that the failure to keep the covenant extended from the priests to the people as a whole. They did not keep covenant with the Lord or with their fellow countrymen when they married foreign women, and they broke their covenants with their wives when they divorced them. The prophet now speaks to his audience as to fellow citizens, with a striking change in style from adversarial indictment ([2:8-9](#)) to inclusive plea ([2:10](#)).

Malachi 2:11

Judah has been unfaithful (or *treacherous*), and a detestable thing has been done in Israel and in Jerusalem: Men were divorcing their wives for the economic advantage of intermarriage with non-

Israelite women who worshiped idols. Through these marriages, Jewish men gained access to the merchant guilds and trading cartels already in place when the Israelites returned from Babylonia. Malachi equates this adultery with idolatry. Israelite history had shown that intermarriage with foreign women went hand in hand with worship of foreign gods. Loyalty was to be the hallmark of Israel's covenant relationships, whether with God or with a marriage partner. Divorce treats with contempt the oneness of the marriage covenant ([2:15](#); see [Gen 2:24](#)).

Malachi 2:12

cut off: The intent was to blot out or destroy evildoers, in contrast to social banishment or religious excommunication.

Malachi 2:14

The expression faithful partner identifies a marriage companion (Greek Old Testament *koinōnos*, "joint partner"). The Hebrew word, used for a seam or a joint in construction (e.g., [Exod 26:6–11](#)), suggests a permanent bond. • marriage vows (literally *covenant*): Marriage is a solemn covenant to which God is witness (see [Prov 2:17](#)).

Malachi 2:16

hate: God hates a broken covenant (see [1:3](#); [Hos 9:15](#)). This is appropriate because God's relationship with people is characterized by faithfulness, and he expected no less from Israel ([Exod 34:6](#); [Deut 7:9](#)). • To divorce (literally *send away*) means to expel a marriage partner. Malachi wanted to correct the abuse of the divorce laws (see [Deut 24:1–4](#)). • to overwhelm her with cruelty: Cruelty entails acts of violence or wrongdoing. The estrangement of divorce is a violent and cruel social crime. To divorce one's wife is treachery against her and against the marriage covenant. It breaks the heart, destroys relationships, violates the integrity of the family, damages the children's well-being, and puts the future in jeopardy.

Malachi 2:17

Malachi's audience had wearied God by questioning his justice.

Malachi 2:17–3:5

Malachi's fourth message concerns the disparity between God's justice and human justice ([2:17](#)). If the book of Malachi were a courtroom drama, the fourth message would be the formal indictment against Judah. Malachi indicts dutiful but heartless religiosity (see [3:14](#)) that acts contrary to God's justice; he appeals for honesty and genuine social concern.

Malachi 3:1

my messenger (Hebrew *mal'aki*): This is a wordplay on Malachi's name. The messenger may be either an angel or a human being functioning as a divine courier. Jesus identified John the Baptist by pointing to this passage (see [Matt 11:10](#); [Mark 1:2](#); [Luke 7:27](#)). • Malachi's audience probably would have understood the messenger of the covenant to be a divine being (cp. [Exod 23:20–23](#)). The Christian church has understood Jesus Christ to be the messenger of the new covenant.

Malachi 3:2

blazing fire: The dross of the people's wickedness must be burned away by the fires of divine testing and chastisement ([Isa 1:25](#); [Jer 6:29](#); [Ezek 22:22](#)). • strong soap: An alkaline detergent was made from plants (see [Jer 2:22](#)). The blazing fire and strong soap signify the testing (by smelting) and cleansing (by laundering) that would restore Israel's faithfulness to its covenant with the Lord.

Malachi 3:5

The words eager to witness suggest a legal proceeding in which God is both prosecuting attorney (accuser) and key witness (provider of evidence) against postexilic Judah. • Sorcerers practiced witchcraft, black magic, or fortune-telling for personal gain. • The coming day of God's judgment would either purify the sinful Judeans ([3:3](#)) or destroy them ([4:1–2](#)).

Malachi 3:6–12

Malachi's fifth message echoes the first ([1:2–5](#)) by emphasizing God's faithfulness to his promises. He calls Israel to a similar faithfulness in worship, especially in giving their tithes and offerings. If Malachi is a courtroom drama, the fifth message is the judge's verdict. The real message is repentance—God wants honest and sincere worship from his people, of which tithing is a symbol.

Malachi 3:7

In the context of covenant relationship, return expresses a change of loyalty on the part of Israel or God. Typically, the term is understood as repentance, a complete change of direction back to God or a total reorientation toward the Lord. The imperative verb conveys urgency and demands an immediate response from the audience. The indictment of insincere worship builds on similar charges in the second disputation (see [1:6–14](#)), just as God's promise to "open the windows of heaven" ([3:10](#)) affirms his power as "a great king" (see [1:14](#)).

Malachi 3:8–9

Malachi appeals to Judah for a comprehensive renewal of their practice of giving to the Lord. • Tithes, a tenth of the produce of the land, were required offerings (see [Deut 12:6, 11, 17](#)). Offerings were additional gifts or contributions made to the Lord or his sanctuary that included produce, material goods (such as construction materials or garments), or personal valuables (such as gold, silver, or precious stones). • Judah's recent experience resulted from God's curse (see [Deut 28:20, 27](#)). Malachi thus urgently called the community to repent, turn to the Lord, and do what the covenant required.

Malachi 3:10

Put me to the test! The divine invitation to test the Lord offers the restoration community an opportunity to prove his faithfulness to his covenant promises.

Malachi 3:12

all nations will call you blessed: Abundant yields of produce would once again show the world the Lord's favor toward Israel.

Malachi 3:13

You have said terrible things about me: The people had accused God of favoring evildoers and had openly questioned his justice (see [2:17](#)), but the Lord loves justice ([Pss 9:16; 37:28](#)).

Malachi 3:13–4:3

Malachi's final message contains two distinct but related speeches, the first emphasizing service to the Lord ([3:13–18](#)) and the second contrasting the fate of the wicked with that of the righteous ([4:1–3](#)). Each speech concludes with the messenger formula (see study note on 1:8). The prophet revisits themes from the fourth message ([3:1–5](#)) as he reiterates God's desire for honesty and faithfulness in worship in view of coming judgment on the day of the Lord. If Malachi is a courtroom drama, this last disputation is the sentencing. While wickedness seems to triumph over righteousness and God seems delinquent in judging sin in the community, the coming day of the Lord will vindicate God's justice as the wicked are separated from the righteous by the fire of God's judgment.

Malachi 3:14

What have we gained? The people assumed that righteous acts would result in material blessing ([Deut 28](#)). • sorry for our sins: The idea was to parade mournfully or walk in funeral garb to demonstrate penitence, as though such acts were righteous in themselves (see [Matt 6:1–18](#)).

Malachi 3:15

To call the arrogant blessed was blasphemy against God's justice (see [3:13](#)).

Malachi 3:16

A scroll of remembrance—a Persian tradition—was a catalog of names with a record of events associated with those individuals. We are not told how many people signed the scroll. • Those who feared him were people who were loyal to the Lord as God, obedient to God's commands, and righteous in conduct and worship.

Malachi 3:16–18

The prophet here serves as a recorder, reporting the audience's reaction to his final message and God's response to the discussion among those who feared the Lord. Although God listened to their deliberations (see [3:16](#)), there is no evidence that Malachi's message effected any real change in the majority of his listeners.

Malachi 3:17

special treasure: Israel had a privileged status as God's people; they were his private property.

Malachi 4:1–3

This message shifts away from the disputation format, directly warning the people that repentance is the only proper response to the Lord's message because God's judgment is inescapable.

Malachi 4:2

The source for the title Sun of Righteousness might have been the winged sun disk that is ubiquitous in ancient Near Eastern iconography. Here it might be a title for the Messiah or a figurative description of a new era of righteousness in which God will overturn the curse of sin. Israel's spiritual restoration, or healing, would be based on God's cleansing the people and forgiving their sins (see [Jer 33:6–8](#); cp. [Jer 8:14–15](#)). It would result from a collective confession of sin and their turning back to God ([Mal 3:7](#); cp. [Jer 14:19–20](#)). • in his wings: Outstretched wings are a symbol of God's protection and rescue (see [Exod 19:4](#); [Deut 32:10–11](#); [Ps 17:8](#); [18:10](#)).

Malachi 4:4

The first postscript reminds Judah to obey the Law of Moses. Israel's identity was rooted in the Exodus and defined by the Sinai covenant mediated by Moses (see [Deut 34:10–12](#)).

Malachi 4:4–6

The book concludes with an epilogue containing appeals to Moses and Elijah, two ideal models of faith in the Lord and of the ideals of the Law and Prophets (see [Matt 17:1–4](#)). The two are upheld as examples for Malachi's audience to follow. In ancient Hebrew tradition, the two appeals may have served as postscripts for the scroll that contained the twelve Minor (shorter) Prophets. If so, the first postscript ([Mal 4:4](#)) connects the scroll to the Law of Moses. The second ([4:5–6](#)) ties the scroll of the Minor Prophets to the Major (longer) Prophets—Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel.

Malachi 4:5–6

The second postscript warns that divine judgment of the wicked is indeed approaching, and promises divine deliverance and restoration of the righteous. • Elijah is a supreme example of a prophet of God who preached repentance with messages that were authenticated by signs and wonders (see [Luke 1:17](#); [Jas 5:17–18](#)). Elijah was a forerunner of the day of the Lord (see [Mal 3:1](#)). The New Testament identifies John the Baptist as the prophet who prepared the way for Jesus the Messiah (see [Matt 11:11–15](#); [Luke 1:17](#)).

Malachi 4:6

His preaching will turn the hearts of fathers to their children: Two key themes prominent in Malachi and the Old Testament prophets in general are the turning of hearts and the ministry of reconciliation. Turn is the Old Testament term for repentance and indicates a complete change of loyalties. Turning toward God results in reconciliation between generations (see [2 Cor 5:18–20](#)). • strike the land with a curse: The word curse implies total destruction (see [Deut 7:26](#); [1 Sam 15:18](#); [Zech 14:11](#)). The people of Israel who did not respond to God's prophet would face utter oblivion, as had

been the fate of their Canaanite predecessors (e.g., [Josh 6:17](#)).